Date of Estimated Return from Overseas (DEROS) for My Soul

By Steve Mason

INTRODUCTION

Steve Mason, a soldier and poet who became the unofficial bard of the Vietnam War, died on May 25 in Ashland, Oregon of lung cancer linked to Agent Orange exposure. He was 65. His poems are as taut and graceful as they are soulful. They are about boys who traded the trumped up battles of their hometown football fields for the deadly ones of Vietnam's mangrove swamps, about men who returned from war to find other men raising their children, about men who, like himself, for 20 years have been toting "the duffel bags of their guilt" along the long road home. Date of Estimated Return from Overseas for My Soul by Steve Mason

At times when I am calm

I remember

that even if you waited for it

nothing came as suddenly

4NG Fanatics

as gunfire

and nothing (not even the Lieutenant)

seemed as stupid

as the silence which followed

At such times I know also

that each of us

who fought in Vietnam

was spiritually captured by it,

and that each remains

a prisoner

of his own war-

It is, therefore, not surprising

that for some (like for me)

the AfterNam emptiness

published no D.E.R.O.S.

for the soul....

Yet, in moments better known to me,

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

when reason drifts
and whole worlds are illuminated
with Platonic images
dancing images
dancing against the cave-walls
of my mind,
lit by a single candle
borrowed from a twilight wish,
I take the stairs two-at-a-time
and wait in the second floor window
of my days,
hoping that someday will come next morning
and that I'll recognize the soul of a much younger me
come diddy-boppin' down the street,
eating a sky-bar
and hefting a duffle bag
filled with new and more believable myths
that I might live by
(not to mention back pay)
while humming something about

4NG Fanatics

going to San Francisco
and something about a flower in somebody's hair

Frankly, I don't know if I'd throw flowers
or run down stairs, meet him at the curb
and beat Hell out of him-
leaving me the way he did!

I mean, it's not like my damned soul,
dressed up like Jennifer Jones in drag,
and waved farewell with a lace hanky
from the base of a Bon-Sai plant
in a To do Street floral shop
while i woke the next morning and
couldn't cry anymore
or laugh like before
or give a shit period.

And my soul didn't go berserk
under the too bright light

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

of a Government Moon
and go roaring down Highway #1
doing a wheelie on a cycle
like James Dean in a steel pot
and flak jacket
laughing Red Baron kind of laugh
and quoting Kipling's Barrack-Room
Ballads--

No.
My soul just did
what most souls did.
Just disappeared one afternoon
when I was in a firefight
Just "walked away" in the scuffle
like a Dunhill lighter
off the deck of a red-neck bar.

Peculiar,
A man can lose his money,

4NG Fanatics

his woman
(even his mind)
and still he can come back,
but if he loses his courage
or his pride
then-
it is over.

And what of a lost soul?
I ask myself
when madness invades
scattering today's headlines
like March Hares
leaving nothing at the table
of my reason
beyond one crumb of truth
and the enormous bloodstain
on the white cloth of my youth-shaped
(if you come around this side
of the table and cock your head

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

just so)
like a distorted lunar projection of Vietnam.

And careful, don't strike your knee
against that table leg
cause then it jumps alive
like somebody flunked
the ink blot test
and knocking over the candelabra
dives out of the window of my sanity
to run naked down the street
lined on both sides by
Vietnam vets
who couldn't sleep either
and just followed the blood trail
like mute somnambulists
in a black and white foreign film
because they heard that tonight
their shared nightmare
(with Vietnamese sub-titles)

4NG Fanatics

had called a muster of lost souls
to be followed by Nam,
Bloody Nam,
leading a one man parade
and twirling a baton
that looked like nobody's penis
I ever saw
and probably belonged
to the guy in back of me
poor bastard.

Geez, it gets scary in here sometimes,
do it not, Burtha?
And oh, sister, do you have songs to
sing?
About war without glory
and love beyond reward.

Maybe someday God will mint a medal so beautiful
no words are printed on it

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

and all of our sisters
who were there with us
would get one
and everyone, everywhere who saw it
would know just what it was
and would find a "thoughtful place"
to go sit down in for a week

And then maybe God would let us have
a picnic (bigger than the moon)
and all the boys and girls
of daddies whose lives they saved
could hold hands
to make a daisy chain for the sun.

And when it was all done
the big people
would make God a prayer-promise
never, never to do anything like Nam
again

4NG Fanatics

And when the cheers died down
the sun would bow his head
ever so slightly
so the children might wish their necklace
`round his head
and when it was in place,
all of a sudden-
faster, even then gunfire,
everybody's lost soul would
just come floating down like a
bright balloon
on a string

and mine would wink at yours
and pretend not to see me
and when everyone got his,
All the children would sing
Happy Birthday! Happy Birthday!!
over and over again.....

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4NG Fanatics

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Steve Mason
Book: Johnny's Song
ISBN: 978-0553051605
Publisher: Bantam Books
Date(Month/Year): April 1986

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY